

Figure I.9 *Wall fragments and piers excavated at Lalkot. © Courtesy of the Archaeological Survey of India, New Delhi.*

are particularly noteworthy. First, during the 1190s CE the Shansabanis' successful campaigns into the north Indian *duab* saw the establishment in the region of *their interpretation* of Perso-Islamic cultures of power[9] (cf. Chapter 1), to be contrasted to the Muslim mercantile presences along the subcontinent's coasts and some inland nodes dating from the eighth century onward.[10] Second, the Shansabani campaigns instigated a broad geo-historical momentum, which lasted through the early sixteenth century: successive waves of Islam-affiliated warlords entered the *duab* along the self-same northwestern corridors and ruled the region with varying longevities. This span of a bit more than three centuries – essentially from the 1190s until the arrival of the Timurid prince Babur (AH 888–936/1483–1530 CE) in 1525 – is generally bracketed in modern scholarship as the Sultanate period.[11]

But, despite four Persian-language monographs within the last fifty years on the Shansabanis, they are still deemed less than consequential in modern Western-language historiography, remaining in the shadows of their more famous contemporaries such as the Ghaznavids of Afghanistan and the Saljuqs of Iran, Central Asia, and Anatolia (*c.* AH 431–590/1040–1194 CE).[12] This striking divergence between Western and "indigenous *epistemological* values" – to modify Thomas de Bruijn's phrase for our immediate purposes[13] – certainly reiterates the fractured and contingent nature of regional "knowledges" at any given time. Indeed, this divergence leaves open the long and probably futile task of integrating "knowledges" into anything near a singular and shared Knowledge, even with the new